FIGURE 5.8 Dagmar Schultz, “Audre Lorde at the Berlin Wall in 1990.” (Dagmar Schultz)

Through her public writing, Lorde responded in numerous pieces to a series of racist attacks on people of color in Germany that coincided with the dismantling of the Wall and reunification. In 1990, along with her partner, Gloria Joseph, Lorde wrote an open letter to German chancellor Helmut Kohl to call attention to the early occurrences of these attacks. In this letter, published in German media outlets, the women outlined their concerns about street violence they learned about on their return trips. “Why has the dismantling of the Berlin Wall meant that we now feel less and less safe as Black Women visitors to ride the U-Bahn in Berlin? … Why must we become more and more afraid to walk the once safe streets around Alexanderplatz in East Berlin after dusk?” They use their intimate knowledge of Berlin, calibrated during their time in the city during its division, to offer a cautionary story about antiblack violence in the reunified city.[31]

In this letter, they presented the violence in Berlin to name the city as a vulnerable diasporic space, going beyond statistics and headlines to illuminate new and pervasive fears. They defended Afro-German women and deployed the grammatical “we” to identify with and remark on the dangers Lorde and Joseph faced as black women spending time in Germany. Lorde remained suspect of rapid geopolitical change without acknowledgment and discussion of the implications for people of color in Germany. She again turned to the symbolism of the Berlin Wall and the divided city for reflection and advocacy.[32]

Between 1987 and her death in 1992, Lorde composed more poems that addressed themes of travel and return. She prepared a manuscript of these poems in the years she fought her illness, but they were published posthumously in the collection *The Marvelous Arithmetics of Distance* (1993). The poet’s habitual relationship with Berlin coincided with the continued rise in awareness of the Afro-German movement, for which she was, in part, responsible for cultivating. Her “Berlin years,” as friend and filmmaker Dagmar Schultz would term them, extended across a time of sweeping change in Germany, in particular the dismantling of the Berlin Wall in 1989 and Germany’s reunification in 1990.

The Marvelous Arithmetics of Distance offers a poetic bridge across this historical divide. As demonstrated in chapter 4, Lorde’s introduction to Berlin occurred in the years of its division. As the demise of the Wall was